



old days. This could adversely affect its agenda for economic revival.

ING THE FIRE

People in the state are viewing the spiralling Sikh-Sacha Sauda confrontation through the prism of the infamous Sikh-Nirankari clash of 1978, which had pushed the state into a decade of terrorism. Incidentally, Badal was the chief minister at that time too. Curiously, while the moderate Shiromani Akali Dal leadership took the backseat, the party's articulate and aggressive acting president, Sukhbir Singh Badal, opted to go abroad when the crisis erupted.

The crisis has exposed the first fault lines in the ruling coalition, with BJP outdoing the Congress in stridently rapping Badal for mishandling the

crisis. It even threatened to pull the plug on the government, saying "the party will not hesitate to take drastic actions", if the sectarian tension imperiled peace in Punjab. BJP is feeling edgy in view of a political fallout. The Government has dithered on taking a tough administrative action and has egged on the SAD-controlled Shiromani Gurdwara Prabandhak Committee (SGPC) to orchestrate the anti-Sacha Sauda tirade. "Badal is using the crisis to consolidate his panthic hegemony but runs the risk of letting the radicals gain ground," says political analyst Harish Puri.

Even before the Akal Takht chief

TROUBLE POT: Sikh youth demand the arrest of Dera's Baba (below)

could read out the *hukamnama* (the edict) that called for a social boycott of the Sacha Sauda and gave a 10-day ultimatum to the Government to take action against the sect, the hardliners rejected it, terming it a "soft option". Not only did the radicals defiantly force the clergy to curtail the ultimatum to three days, they also threatened a direct action against the Sacha Sauda Deras. The same evening, a mob of 10,000 Sikh protesters attacked three deras in Malwa region, leaving one person dead and a dozen injured in Sunam.

A tense standoff ensued with the Sacha Sauda chief refusing to apologise for his allegedly blasphemous act. "I have committed no sacrilege," said Baba Gurmeet, with a touch of defiance, while thousands of emotionally-charged supporters demanded dismissal of the Badal Government. It took the government a week to register an FIR against him.

Controversy has followed Sacha Sauda chief like a shadow. He is already under the CBI scanner in two murder cases and another case relating to alleged sexual exploitation of resident women devotees inside the dera. CBI is expected to file a status report in the Punjab and Haryana High Court by May 26. It is widely believed that the Sacha Sauda chief's controversial ritual was essentially a "show of strength" and meant to send a veiled warning to the Centre against nailing him in the investigations. In October 2002, Sirsa-based journalist, Ram Chander Chattarpati, who had reported the allegations against the dera in his newspaper *Poora Sach*, was murdered. Two of the assailants, who were nabbed on the spot, were Sacha Sauda followers. Subsequently, the high court ordered a CBI probe in 2002—a development that evoked strong protests from dera devotees who deluged the Prime Minister's Office with sworn affidavits, threatening mass suicide if Baba Gurmeet was implicated by the investigative team. "CBI has been arm-twisting the Dera followers to name 'Pita ji' in the murder cases," says Dera spokesperson Dr Aditya Arora, a post-graduate from AIIMS.